

AROMATHERAPY



Outlines

- Definition, Historical background of Aromatherapy
- Principles and laws of cure
- Areas of practice
- Methods and materials used in the healing process
- Advantages and disadvantages

Definition & Historical Background

Aromatherapy a **holistic healing practice** that use essential oils extracted from flowers, bark, stems, leaves, roots or other parts of a plant to enhance:

- Psychological and physical well-being (therapeutic or medicinal purposes)
- Altering a person's mind, mood, cognitive function or health

- Essential oils have been used for therapeutic purposes for nearly 6,000 years
- Ancient Chinese, Indians, Egyptians, Greeks, and Romans used them in cosmetics, perfumes, and as drugs.
- Essential oils were used for spiritual, ritualistic, hygienic & therapeutic purposes
- **Pedanius Dioscorides** the father of pharmacognosy, described healing properties of essential oils in De Materia Medica

- The term aromatherapy was coined and first appeared in print in 1937 in the book **Aromathérapie: Les Huiles Essentielles Hormones Végétales**, authored by the French chemist René-Maurice Gattefossé.
- He discovered healing properties of lavender oil when applied to a burn on his hand after a laboratory explosion.

- **Jean Valnet**, who was an army physician and surgeon, From 1948 he set about trying to prove the nature and uses of essential oils in scientific terms.
- Jean Valnet decided to further investigate the medicinal benefits of essential oils by using them as an antiseptic for wounded soldiers during World War II
- He Have also demonstrated their efficacy as a dental mouthwash products

Other stated uses include:

- Pain and anxiety reduction
- Enhancement of energy & short-term memory
- Relaxation
- Hair loss prevention
- Reduction of eczema-induced itching

Principles and laws of cure

A. Principles of Aromatherapy

The philosophy of aromatherapy integrates elements from traditional medicine systems, focusing on restoring balance to the mind, body, and spirit.

- **Holistic health:** aromatherapy treats the whole person, not just the symptoms (considering physical, psychological, and emotional well-being).
- **Stimulating self-healing:** a key principle is to strengthen the body's innate healing mechanisms (often referred to as "life force" or chi) through the use of organic, plant-derived essential oils.

- **Balancing forces:** derived from Traditional Chinese Medicine, the concept of balancing opposing forces (yin and yang) is applied, with essential oils used to restore harmony and equilibrium within the body.
- **Natural origin:** essential oils are natural products extracted from plants and, when used correctly, are believed to work in harmony with the body, often without the negative side effects associated with some conventional medicines.

Laws of cure

- Aromatherapy, as a complementary therapy, does not have its own specific set of formal, legally binding "laws of cure" akin to established scientific or medical laws.
- Instead, practitioners may sometimes reference **Hering's Law of Cure**, a principle originating from homeopathy which describes the typical order in which symptoms disappear during a successful healing process:

- **From center to circumference:** healing begins in core areas (e.g., vital organs) and moves outward to the extremities (e.g., skin).
- **From above downward:** symptoms resolve from the top of the body downwards.
- **In reverse order of appearance:** the most recent symptoms disappear first, while older, chronic symptoms disappear later.

This is a theoretical framework for observing the healing progression within alternative medicine practices.

Mechanism of cure

1. Olfactory stimulation and limbic system interaction

- It involves olfactory stimulation, where volatile compounds interact with the limbic system of the brain, influencing our mood, memory and hormone balance

2. Biochemical and neurological pathways

- Aromatherapy's therapeutic mechanisms operate through a sophisticated interplay of biochemical and neurological pathways.
- When essential oil molecules enter the nasal cavity, they trigger a cascade of neural responses that extend far beyond simple scent perception.
- These molecular interactions initiate signals that travel directly to the limbic system, bypassing the thalamic relay that most sensory information requires, which explains the immediate emotional and physiological responses often experienced with aromatic compound

3. Chemical complexity and entourage effect

- The chemical complexity of essential oils forms the foundation of their therapeutic potential.
- These natural compounds contain hundreds of different molecules, predominantly terpenes and their derivatives, each contributing to the oil's overall therapeutic effect.
- Terpenes, particularly monoterpenes and sesquiterpenes, demonstrate remarkable biological activities including anti-inflammatory, anxiolytic, and antimicrobial properties.
- This molecular diversity creates what researchers term the “**entourage effect**,” where the combination of compounds produces more significant therapeutic benefits than individual components in isolation.

4. Self-healing and immune system stimulation

- The basic principle of Aromatherapy is to strengthen the self-healing processes by indirect stimulation of the immune system.

5. Psychological influence and preventative health

- Aromas have a strong psychological influence over us, some aromas are not pleasant and warn us of physical danger, such as fire or something rotten, and this can help our health in a preventative way.
- To use aromas positively and beneficially is therapeutic

Areas of practice

- The areas of practice and application are diverse and generally focus on managing symptoms and enhancing overall quality of life.
- Basic area of practice in aromatherapy includes **therapeutic applications, aesthetic purposes, and psycho-aromatherapy.**

1. Therapeutic aromatherapy

- Is used to help relieve various physical discomforts and symptoms.
- It focuses on the natural properties of essential oil such as anesthetic, bactericidal, anti-inflammatory, antibiotic, and antiviral qualities for healing purposes.

- This area is beneficial for symptom management in various conditions, including pain, nausea, anxiety, depression, stress, insomnia, and respiratory issues.
- Techniques such as inhalation, topical application, and massage integrate these natural substances to promote relaxation, relieve pain, and enhance overall well-being.

- For instance, sweet fennel (*Foeniculum vulgare* var. dulce) is from the plant family Apiaceae. Uses for this oil include an anti-inflammatory, antibacterial, antifungal, antispasmodic, detoxifier, and digestive and for relieving gas
- Eucalyptus is a tree from the plant family Myrtaceae. It also is referred to by many names, such eucalyptus oil, blue gum oil, blue mallee oil, and gully gum oil.
- The leaves and twigs are used for burns, wounds, **lowering blood glucose, nasal congestion, asthma and as a tick repellent**. It also is used in medications and supplements.

2. Aesthetic aromatherapy

- Aromatherapy isn't just for health; it's also a powerful tool in the beauty and skincare world.
- Essential oils can be used to boost regular skin and hair routine.
- Some essential oils help to balance the natural oil (sebum) on skin, keeping it smooth and moisturized.
- Other oils help improve blood flow and encourage skin to grow new, healthy cells.

- Many oils can be applied to hydrate, moisturize, and make older skin look refreshed and younger.
- **For example,** rosemary essential oil promotes cellular production; it may help increase hair thickness and growth.

- **Lavender oil** offers immense skin benefits due to its antiseptic and anti-inflammatory properties, effectively treating minor irritations, cuts, and burns while reducing redness, making it ideal for sensitive skin.
- As a potent antioxidant, it wards off pre-aging conditions and is excellent for acne-prone skin because it cools blemishes, incites healing, and calms the complexion.

3. Psycho aromatherapy

- This area explores the emotional and psychological effects of essential oils, the interactions with the nervous system, with emotions, memory and the unconscious.
- It is the use of essential oils to help resolve emotional imbalances and enhance psychological wellness.
- Through **inhalation or the external application** of essential oils in massages or baths, the brain may be either relaxed or stimulated.

Materials used in aromatherapy

The primary materials used in aromatherapy for the healing process are Essential Oils and Carrier Oils, along with various methods of delivery.

1. Essential oils (EOs)

- These are highly concentrated, aromatic liquid extracts from plants, capturing the plant's "essence" and therapeutic properties. They are derived from the plant's flowers, leaves, stalks, bark, rind, or roots.

Examples of popular essential oils used for healing:

Essential oils	Common uses
Lavender	Relaxation, stress relief, sleep, soothing minor burns/cuts, anti-inflammatory
Eucalyptus	Respiratory issues, decongestant, antimicrobial, anti-inflammatory
Peppermint	Muscle tension relief, headaches, digestive issues (e.g., IBS symptoms), invigorating.
Tea tree	Antiseptic, antimicrobial, antifungal (for skin/nail issues).
Chamomile	Calming, anxiety relief, pain relief (e.g., headaches), skin soothing.
Frankincense	Meditation, inflammation, mood, skincare, general healing.
Lemon/Citrus	Mood enhancement, stimulating, cleansing, alertness.



2. Carrier oils

- Essential oils are potent and must be diluted before topical application to the skin to prevent irritation.
- Carrier oils are the fatty, non-volatile vegetable oils derived from the seeds, nuts, or kernels of plants, and they "carry" the essential oil onto the skin.
- They also offer their own moisturizing and nourishing benefits.

Examples of common carrier oils:

- **Jojoba oil:** Closely mimics the skin's natural oil (sebum), good for most skin types.
- **Fractionated coconut oil:** Lightweight, liquid at room temperature, easily absorbed, great all-purpose oil.
- **Sweet almond oil:** Good for dry skin, lightweight, popular for massage.
- **Apricot kernel oil:** Rich in Vitamin E and fatty acids, good for irritated skin.
- **Rosehip oil:** Often used for anti-aging and skin regeneration.



3. Other aromatic materials and tools

- **Hydrosols** : also known as "flower waters," they have similar properties to essential oils, these aromatic waters are much less concentrated.
- **Absolutes**: Highly concentrated, aromatic plant extracts, often used in perfumery.
- **Diffusers**: Devices used to disperse essential oils into the air for inhalation.
- **Inhalers**: Personal devices for direct inhalation of essential oil aromas.
- **Bath Salts/Lotions/Creams**: Bases into which essential oils are blended for topical application or bathing.

Methods used in aromatherapy for healing process

A. Inhalation

- Inhalation is a highly effective delivery method, particularly for emotional and respiratory support.
- Due to the volatility of essential oils, inhaled molecules rapidly reach the respiratory tract and lungs, providing swift access to the bloodstream.
- The exposure of EOs via the respiratory tract is often more rapid compared to dermal absorption.

Inhalation techniques range from direct application to a tissue or personal inhaler, to adding oils to steaming water, or using mechanical diffusers. Diffuser technology varies significantly in terms of delivery:

- **Ultrasonic diffusers:** these use water and vibrational energy to create a gentle, diluted mist. They are suitable for providing subtle ambient fragrance and adding humidity.

Nebulizing Diffuser **VS** Ultrasonic Diffuser



- **Nebulizing diffusers:** these devices atomize pure essential oils without requiring water or heat. They produce a potent, concentrated aroma mist, making them highly effective for targeted therapeutic use or in smaller clinical spaces.

B. Dermal application techniques

- Topical application is the foundation of physical symptom management in clinical aromatherapy. Essential oils, combined with vegetable and nut oils, are massaged into the skin, added to lotions, or incorporated into compresses.
- Massage facilitates the absorption of EO molecules into the circulatory system while providing the complementary benefits of manual manipulation, which can enhance relief for pain and psychological stress.

- **Compresses:** Soaking a cloth in hot or cold water mixed with essential oil (and a carrier oil) and applying it to an affected area (e.g., a sore muscle or bruise).
- **Skin Products:** Incorporating oils into lotions, salves, and creams for specific skin conditions or general skin nourishment.



C. Water immersion (baths or foot baths)

- Bath is another delivery method, though EOs must always be thoroughly mixed with an emulsifier (carrier oil, dispersant salt, or alcohol) before adding to the water to prevent the concentrated oil from irritating the skin.



Tips for using essential oils in aromatherapy

1. Always dilute essential oils before putting them on your skin.
2. Don't use or store essential oils near open flames.
3. Don't drink or otherwise consume essential oils.
4. Keep essential oils away from children and pets.

What are the risks of aromatherapy?

- Skin irritation.
- Allergic contact dermatitis.
- Skin discoloration when you're exposed to sunlight (photosensitivity).

Summary

- Aromatherapy is a form of complementary and alternative medicine (CAM). It uses essential oils to manage symptoms or boost well-being.
- It's a holistic therapy, meaning it supports whole self -mind, body and spirit.
- Aromatherapy involves inhaling essential oils or applying them (diluted) to the skin.

References

- Aromatherapy, cleaveland clinic
- Basic Areas of Practice in Aromatherapy (Essential Oil)
- Drpradeepalbert-the science of aromatherapy mechanisms evidence and clinical applications
- Farrar, A. J., & Farrar, F. C. (2020). Clinical Aromatherapy.
- Naturalwellness – the philosophy principles and practices of aromatherapy
- The World Journal of Pharmaceutical Sciences

THANK YOU

GROUP MEMBERS

ABEBE BEKELE	UGR/1605/15
ABENEZER ALICE	UGR/7733/15
ABIRHAM MINUYE	UGR/3192/15
ABISA MESFIN	UGR/8353/15
AFRAH ISMAIL	UGR/0372/15
AHLAM SHEMSU	UGR/5071/15
AIESHA AHMED	UGR/3936/15
ALEBES MAMO	UGR/8602/15
AMANUEL DEBEBE	UGR/6075/15
AMANUEL WALIE	UGR/1518/13
HANNA NAOH	UGR/1584/14